

Narrative Therapy

Foundations

Stories shape meaning.

Narrative therapy began in the 1980s as a counseling approach rooted in postmodern thought. It emphasizes collaboration and focuses on the role of stories in shaping people's lives.

Assumptions

People are not problems.

Problems arise when restrictive narratives dominate. These stories are shaped by culture and power, but therapy helps loosen their hold so new possibilities emerge.

Role of Stories

Narratives guide identity.

Stories shape identity and relationships. Therapy creates space for alternative stories that honor strengths and values.

Client-Therapist Relationship

Collaboration builds agency and self-efficacy.

The client-therapist relationship is built on collaboration, curiosity, and respect. Rather than acting as experts, therapists work as co-authors who join clients in shaping new stories. Clients remain the primary authors of their lives, while therapists gently challenge dominant narratives that restrict possibilities and highlight strengths, resilience, and agency.

Externalizing

The problem is separate.

Narrative therapists shift language so that problems are viewed as separate from people. This opens space for clients to explore their relationship with the problem rather than internalizing blame.

Deconstruction

Find hidden assumptions.

Therapists work with clients to examine dominant cultural discourses that shape identity and behavior. Making these assumptions visible creates opportunities for new perspectives and choices

Exceptions

Notice pattern breaks.

Therapists highlight times when the problem story did not dominate, or was not present. These *unique outcomes* serve as seeds for alternative stories

Re-authoring

Create preferred stories.

Through conversation, clients and therapists build narratives that align with clients' values and strengths. This process expands identity beyond problem-saturated accounts

Example questions

- When did the problem first show up?
- What does the problem try to say about you?
- Where did you first learn this story?
- Was there a time you handled things differently?
- What made that moment possible?
- What story would you like to live by?

References

Epston, D., & White, M. (2023). *Narrative means to therapeutic ends*. Norton.

Freedman, J., & Combs, G. (1996). *Narrative therapy: The social construction of preferred realities* (1st ed). Norton.